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### Toy figurine and packaging

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#### Abstract

A toy figurine and/or toy figurine packaging is coated with a dissolvable layer. When the toy figurine is coated, the toy figurine is entirely coated so that its overall appearance, including its skin complexion and/or facial features, is substantially hidden or obscured. Then, when the figurine is submerged in a fluid, the dissolvable layer dissolves to reveal the figurine's appearance that had been hidden underneath the dissolvable layer. When the toy figurine packaging is coated, the toy figurine packaging hides the identity of a toy figurine enclosed therein until fluid is introduced to the packaging.

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#### **Background/Summary**

CROSS REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) This application is a continuation of Ser. No. 18/165,600, filed Feb. 7, 2023, which claims priority to and is based on U.S. patent application Ser. No. 17/156,745, filed Jan. 25, 2021, now U.S. Pat. No. 11,607,621, which claims priority to and is based on U.S. Patent Application No. 62/964,941, filed Jan. 23, 2020, entitled “Toy Figurine and Packaging.” The entire disclosures of each of the foregoing applications are incorporated herein by reference.

## FIELD OF THE INVENTION

(1) The present application relates generally to toy dolls and/or figurines and, in particular, to toy dolls/figurines and/or packaging for toy dolls/figurines that can reveal an appearance of a toy doll/figurine.

## BACKGROUND

(2) Through the years, toy dolls and/or figurines (for simplicity, referred to herein as figurines or toy figurines) have provided amusement and entertainment for children. That is, toy dolls and figurines have some inherent play value. To increase this play value, various features, such as action or movement features, have been incorporated into some figurines (e.g., so that figurines can appear to walk, crawl, talk, etc.).

(3) Additionally or alternatively, some figurines allow a user to modify the appearance of the figurine. For example, a toy figurine might include thermochromic hair, layered clothing, features that move to “transform” the doll (e.g., from a mermaid to a princess), or other such appearance changing features. As one example of a figurine with appearance changing features, U.S. Pat. No. 5,032,102, which is issued to Davidson et al. and entitled TOY FIGURE HAVING WATER DISSOLVABLE CLOTHES AND FACIAL ELEMENTS, discloses a doll with a combination of waterproof materials and overlying fabric layers or facial appearance elements formed of a water dissolvable fabric or water dissolvable material, respectively. Thus, when the doll is immersed in water, the dissolvable fabric layers and dissolvable facial appearance elements are dissolved and expose the underlying waterproof elements.

(4) Despite the foregoing, there is a continuing need for ever more interesting and varied doll features, for example, to surprise or entertain a child. In particular, while the features of U.S. Pat. No. 5,032,102 may be interesting and engage a user, the features may provide a limited amount of surprise or suspense for the user, as the user can typically see the doll's overall appearance before or during exposure of the underlying waterproof elements.

## SUMMARY

(5) A toy figurine and a toy set including a toy figurine are presented herein. In at least some embodiments, the toy figurine is coated with a dissolvable layer. More specifically, the toy figurine is entirely coated so that its overall appearance, including its skin complexion and facial features, is substantially hidden or obscured. Then, when the figurine is submerged in a fluid, the dissolvable layer dissolves to reveal the figurine's appearance that had been hidden underneath the dissolvable layer. Additionally or alternatively, packaging for the toy figurine may be coated with the dissolvable layer so that when a fluid is poured onto or into the packaging, an overall appearance of the figurine is revealed. Thus, the toy figurine and/or the packaging presented herein may provide a surprise for the user, adding to the play value of the toy figurine.

(6) Other systems, methods, features and advantages will be, or will become, apparent to one with skill in the art upon examination of the following figures and detailed description. All such additional systems, methods, features and advantages are included within this description, are within the scope of the claimed subject matter.

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## Description

## BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) The toy figurine and packaging presented herein may be better understood with reference to the following drawings and description. The elements in the figures are not necessarily to scale, emphasis instead being placed upon illustrating the principles of the toy figurine. In the figures, like-referenced numerals designate corresponding parts throughout the different views.
- (2) FIG. 1 is a front view of an example embodiment of a toy set including an example embodiment of the toy figurine with a dissolvable layer presented herein.
- (3) FIG. 2 is a front view of the toy set of FIG. 1 while packaging included in the toy set is being opened.
- (4) FIG. 3 is a front view of the toy set of FIG. 1 with an outer casing removed so that the toy figurine is visible through the packaging.
- (5) FIG. 4 is a front view of the packaging of FIG. 1 with the outer casing and a top lid removed.
- (6) FIG. 5 is a sectional view of a portion of the toy figurine of FIG. 3 that illustrates the dissolvable layer and an underlying body of the toy figurine.
- (7) FIG. 6 is a front view of a portion of the packaging of FIG. 1 while being filled with a fluid.
- (8) FIGS. 7-9 are front views of the portion of the packaging of FIG. 6 that illustrate the toy figurine of FIG. 3 being submerged into the fluid.
- (9) FIG. 10 is a front view of the portion of the packaging of FIG. 6 and toy figurine of FIG. 3 after the toy figurine has been removed from the fluid.
- (10) FIGS. 11A and 11B illustrate accessories that may be included in the toy set of FIG. 1, prior to and subsequent to being removed from their accessory packaging.
- (11) FIGS. 12, 13A, and 13B illustrate interplay between one of the accessories illustrated in FIG. 11B and thermochromic features included in or on the underlying body of the toy figurine.
- (12) FIG. 14 illustrates five example underlying bodies that may be hidden under a dissolvable layer with corresponding accessories secured thereto.
- (13) FIG. 15 illustrates a side view of an example embodiment of a toy set including an example embodiment of the toy figurine packaging with a dissolvable layer presented herein.
- (14) FIG. 16A illustrates a back perspective view of the toy figurine packaging of FIG. 15, the toy figurine packaging being partially disassembled.
- (15) FIG. 16B illustrates a top view of a base of a lid of the toy figurine packaging of FIG. 15.
- (16) FIGS. 17-19 are back perspective views of the portion of the toy figurine packaging of FIG. 15 that illustrate fluid being introduced into the toy figurine packaging.
- (17) FIG. 20 illustrates a toy figurine while removed from the toy figurine packaging of FIG. 15, the toy figurine packaging being shown subsequent to a fluid being introduced into the toy figurine packaging.
- (18) FIGS. 21 and 22 illustrate perspective views of a lid included in the toy figurine packaging of FIG. 15.
- (19) FIG. 23 illustrates a perspective view of a lid removal mechanism included in the toy figurine packaging of FIG. 15.

## DETAILED DESCRIPTION

- (20) The toy figurine and/or the toy packaging presented herein includes a dissolvable layer. For example, in at least some embodiments, a toy figurine is entirely coated with a dissolvable layer so that its overall appearance is substantially hidden or obscured. When a figurine body underlying the dissolvable layer is obscured, at least the skin complexion and/or facial features of the underlying figurine body may be hidden or obscured. Consequently, a user may not be able to identify the toy figurine as a particular character from a set of characters when the underlying figurine body is covered with the dissolvable layer. When the figurine is submerged in a fluid, the dissolvable layer dissolves to reveal the figurine's appearance (e.g., at least the skin complexion and/or facial features) that had been hidden underneath the dissolvable layer. Additionally or alternatively,

packaging for the toy figurine may include the dissolvable layer so that the identity of the figurine, features of the toy figurine (e.g., its skin complexion, facial features, etc.) are obscured or hidden. Thus, the toy figurine and/or the toy figurine packaging presented herein may provide a surprise for the user, adding to the play value of the toy figurine.

(21) FIGS. 1 and 2 depict a toy set **10** that includes an example embodiment of a toy figurine with a dissolvable layer. The toy set **10** includes packaging **100** with a vessel **120** within which toy figurine **200** may be packaged, perhaps together with accessories **260**. Generally, the vessel **120** is sized to receive a fluid (e.g., fluid F1 as shown in FIGS. 6-9) within which the figurine **200** may be submerged to remove a dissolvable layer **250** (see, for example, FIGS. 3 and 4) of the figurine **200**. In the depicted embodiment, the vessel **120** is a transparent, cylindrical, open-top vessel **120** defined by a sidewall **122** and bottom **124**. The bottom **124** closes a first end of the sidewall **122** and an opposite end of the sidewall **122** defines an open top **128**. Thus, the bottom **124** and sidewall **122** collectively define a compartment “C” that can receive a fluid within which the toy figurine can be submerged. The compartment C may define a fixed volume that is specifically sized to allow a dissolvable layer to be removed from a figurine and to obscure the figurine as the dissolvable layer is removed.

(22) Moreover, in the depicted embodiment, the entire vessel **120** is transparent (e.g., so that a user can watch a removal of the dissolvable layer **250** occurring within the vessel **120**). However, in other embodiments, the vessel **120** may be any size or shape and one or more portions of the vessel **120** may be transparent while one or more other portions are opaque, reflective, etc. Additionally, as mentioned, in some embodiments, at least a portion of the vessel **120** may be covered (e.g., coated) with a dissolvable layer, either instead of or in addition to the dissolvable layer **250** included on the toy figurine **200**. An example of packaging with a dissolvable layer is described below in connection with FIGS. 15-23.

(23) In the depicted embodiment, the packaging **100** also includes outer packaging **110** and a lid **130**. The outer packaging **110** may be opaque and may substantially cover the sidewall **122** of the vessel **120** so that the toy figurine **200** is hidden from view at a point of sale location, insofar as, in this instance, the term “substantially” is intended to denote coverage of more than 80%, 85%, 90%, 95%, or any other percentage between 70-100% of the sidewall **122**. That is, the outer packaging **110** may be an annular element that extends from a top edge **114** adjacent or proximate the open top **128** of the vessel **120** to a bottom edge **116** adjacent or proximate the bottom **124** of the vessel **120**. As can be seen in FIG. 2, the outer packaging **110** may also include a removal element **112**, such as a tear strip and/or a perforation that allows for easy removal of the outer packaging **110**. Once the outer packaging **110** is removed from the vessel **120**, a user may be able to view the dissolvable layer **250** of the toy figurine **200** (as shown in FIG. 2). Thus, outer packaging **110** may create a first surprise element for the user that reveals the figurine **200** without revealing the entire or overall appearance of the toy figurine **200** (as is explained in further detail below).

(24) Still referring to FIGS. 1 and 2, but now with reference to FIGS. 3 and 4 as well, the lid **130** may removably close the vessel **120**. In the depicted embodiment, this removable closure is achieved with threading. In particular, the lid includes a sidewall **136** with internal threading (not shown) configured to engage and mate with threads **126** included on the vessel **120** adjacent the open top **128** (see FIG. 4). Once the lid **130** is threaded onto the vessel **120**, a bottom surface of the lid **130** (not shown) may, in at least some embodiments, seal the compartment C to provide a watertight enclosure. Thus, in at least some embodiments, the figurine **200** might be sealed in a fluid-filled compartment C and the entire vessel **120** can be shook or otherwise agitated to cause removal of the dissolvable layer **250** of the figurine. Sealing the compartment C may form a fixed volume, for example, in the range of approximately 1.5 Liters to approximately 2 Liters.

(25) In the depicted embodiment, a top surface **134** of the lid **130** also includes a hook **135** that allows the toy set **10** to be stored or display on a rod. However, in other embodiments, the lid **130**, vessel **120**, or outer packaging **110** may also include other elements that facilitate storage and/or

display in any desirable manner. Similarly, in various embodiments, any portion of packaging **100** may incorporate unshown elements like doll stands, play accessories, and the like, in any desirable manner (e.g., the top surface **134** or the bottom surface of lid **130** may include or define a doll stand).

(26) In FIG. **3**, the outer packaging **110** has been removed and, thus, the toy figurine **200** is visible from an exterior of the vessel **120**. However, since the dissolvable layer **250** entirely covers the figurine **200**, the underlying body **210** (see FIG. **10**) and overall appearance of the figurine **200** may still be hidden from the user. More specifically, the dissolvable layer **250** may hide or obscure at least the skin complexion **212** (see FIG. **10**), facial features **222** (see FIG. **10**), and/or clothing **236** (see FIG. **10**) of the figurine **20**, while showing the overall shape/features of the figurine. Thus, when the dissolvable layer **250** is disposed on the toy figurine **200**, a user (e.g., a child) may be unable to determine which character (e.g., from a set of characters) they have in their possession. That is, the dissolvable layer **250** may allow a user to discern that the toy is a toy figurine, but may hide the identity of the figurine **20**.

(27) That said, when the toy figurine **200** is disposed within the packaging **100**, the toy figurine **200** may be in a first position P1. In at least some embodiments, the toy figurine **200** may be covered (e.g., sprayed, painted, or otherwise coated) with the dissolvable layer **250** while in position P1 and, thus, the underlying body **210** (see FIG. **10**) may be entirely covered when in position P1 but may be slightly visible if the toy figurine is moved out of position P1 (e.g., when the figurine is posed). Thus, for the purposes of this application, the term “entirely covered” may mean that the toy figurine is covered with a dissolvable layer **250** so that the underlying body **210** is hidden from view at least when the toy figurine is disposed in the position in which it is coated, sold, and/or packaged (e.g., position P1).

(28) As a specific example, in the depicted embodiment, the toy figurine **200** includes head **220** that is movably mounted on a neck **240**, arms **242** that are movably mounted to a torso **230** at shoulder joints **232** (e.g., ball joints), and legs **244** that are movably mounted to torso **230** at hip joints **234** (e.g., ball joints). In position P1, the head **220** is looking straight ahead, both arms **242** are straight down at the sides of the figurine **200**, and both legs **244** are positioned straight down. With these movable parts in these positions, none of the underlying body **210** is visible. That is, with these movable parts in these positions, the dissolvable layer **250** covers or hides the entire underlying body **210**. However, if the figurine **200** were removed from the packaging **100** and one of the movable portions of the figurine **200** were moved/posed (e.g., if an arm **242** were raised above the head **220**), the underlying body **210** may become slightly visible at the joint facilitating the movement (e.g., at the shoulder **232** for movement of arm **242**). Nevertheless, as mentioned above, the depicted embodiment may be referred to as being entirely covered by the dissolvable layer **250**.

(29) Importantly, since the dissolvable layer **250** entirely covers the underlying body **210**, facial features **222** (see FIG. **10**), such as hair **224** (see FIG. **10**), eyes **225** (see FIG. **10**), and lips **226** (see FIG. **10**) are obscured or hidden from view. Notably, in the depicted embodiment, to hide the hair **224** under the dissolvable layer **250**, the hair **224** is short and sculpted from plastic, but, in other embodiments, longer strands of hair **224** might be included on the figurine **200** and coated with the dissolvable layer **250**. Additionally or alternatively, the skin complexion **212** (see FIG. **10**) of the figurine **200** and/or clothing **236** (see FIG. **10**) included on the torso **230** of the underlying body **210** is/are obscured or hidden from view. This provides a second surprise element for the user, since even after removing packaging **100** the user (e.g., the child) may be unable to ascertain which character they have obtained (e.g., purchased).

(30) Although the depicted embodiments illustrate figurine **200** as a human figurine, the figurine presented herein need not be a figurine. For example, in other embodiments, the figurine might be an animal, mythical character, humanoid, alien, etc. Regardless of its form, the figurine **200** will be entirely covered with the dissolvable layer **250** that hides an overall appearance of the figurine **200**.

(e.g., by hiding facial features, complexion, color, and/or other identifying features) until the dissolvable layer **250** is removed from the figurine **200**. Moreover, although “entirely covering” may involve covering the figurine in a first position P1, the position P1 need not be a standing position like the illustrated position P1 and may be any position (e.g., a sitting position, walking position (human or animal), etc.).

(31) Still further, to be clear, the term “entirely covered” does not require that the overall shape of a toy be hidden. Instead, a toy can be coated or sprayed in a manner that entirely covers the toy figurine **200** without hiding its shape and/or features (e.g., without hiding that the figurine **200** is a human figurine). Thus, the terms “coated,” “coating,” “coat(s),” and the like, are used herein to denote that the shape and/or features of a covered toy (e.g., figurine **200**) are not hidden when a toy is entirely covered. For example, the depicted toy figurine **200** is entirely covered with a thin conformal film that coats the underlying body **210**. Thus, the arms, legs, and overall structure of the toy figurine **200** are discernable when the dissolvable layer **250** is on the toy figurine **200**, but the overall appearance (e.g., the identity) is hidden.

(32) FIG. 5 depicts a sectional view of a portion of figurine **200** that depicts the dissolvable layer **250** entirely covering a portion of the underlying body **210** of figurine **200**. Generally, the underlying body **210** may be formed from a plastic material that is painted, dyed, or otherwise colored with waterproof materials. For example, the underlying body **210**, or at least a portion thereof, may be formed from colored plastic that holds its color when exposed to water. This type of plastic may define the complexion **212** of the underlying body **210**. Additionally or alternatively, the underlying body **210**, or at least a portion thereof, may be formed from thermochromic materials that change color in response to hot or cold energy, as is disclosed in U.S. Pat. No. 5,503,583, which is issued to Hippely et al. and which is entitled TOY WITH THERMOCHROMIC MATERIAL, the entirety of which is hereby incorporated by reference.

(33) For example, the legs **244**, arms **242**, neck **240**, and a portion of head **220** may be formed from a plastic of a first color and/or painted/dyed with a waterproof material of the first color so that these portions of figurine **200** define a complexion **212** of figurine **200** (see FIG. 10). Meanwhile, the torso **230** may be formed from a plastic of a second color and/or painted/dyed with a waterproof material of at least a second color so that the torso **230** defines clothing **236** (e.g., a onesie, unitard, shirt, and/or tank top) on the underlying body **210** of the figurine **200** (see FIG. 10). Still further, facial features **222** on the head **220** may be formed from thermochromic material so that the facial features **222** on the underlying body **210** can change color when exposed to hot or cold energy (e.g., hot or cold water), as is explained in further detail in connection with FIGS. 12, 13A, and 13B.

(34) In contrast with the underlying body **210**, the dissolvable layer **250** is formed from a material that dissolves when immersed in a fluid, such as water. For example, the dissolvable layer **250** may be a water dissolvable layer of paint that can be applied to the underlying body **210** (e.g., via any combination of spraying, brushing, dipping, etc.) to form a thin, conformal film thereover. Unlike traditional paints, the dissolvable layer of paint may lack a cross-linker or curing agent so that the paint is easily dissolvable. For example, according to some embodiments, the dissolvable layer **250** may be a paint composed of approximately 40-60% water, approximately 15-22% organic solvent (e.g., ethanol), approximately 10-20% pigment/colorant, approximately 10-20% water soluble resin, approximately 0-3% film forming agent, approximately 0.5-3% dispersing agent, approximately 0-3% humectant, and approximately 0-2% matting agent (e.g., silica)

(35) In at least some embodiments, the dissolvable material that is used to form the dissolvable layer **250** is configured to decouple from the underlying body **210** upon exposure to a fluid (e.g., fluid F1) and mix into the fluid to color the fluid. This may cause the fluid to become opaque, thereby hiding the underlying body **210** from view during a “transformation.” This may create a third surprise element for the toy set **10** (e.g., since the user must remove the figurine **200** from a fluid F1 to see the underlying body **210**). In at least some embodiments, the figurine **200** can



simply be dunked into a fluid F1 to remove the dissolvable layer **250** from the underlying body **210** but, in other embodiments, the figurine **200** and/or the fluid F1 may need to be agitated (e.g., by spinning the figurine **200**, sealing and shaking the vessel **120**, etc.) to remove the dissolvable layer **250** from the underlying body **210**.

(36) Now turning to FIGS. **6-10**, these figures illustrate an example transformation of the figurine **200** according to an example embodiment. That is, FIGS. **6-10** illustrate an example removal of the dissolvable layer **250** from the underlying body **210**. Initially, as shown in FIG. **6**, the compartment C of the vessel **120** is filled with a warm fluid F1. Then, as shown in FIG. **7**, the figurine **200** is submerged or immersed (e.g., dunked) into the fluid F1 disposed in compartment C. As is shown in FIGS. **8** and **9**, after a few seconds of immersion, the dissolvable layer **250** begins to dissolve (and detach from the underlying body **210**) and begins to cloud the fluid F1 so that it becomes cloudy fluid F1', until eventually the fluid F1 becomes an opaque fluid F1''.

(37) In at least some embodiments, the fixed volume of the compartment C is specifically sized to ensure that the compartment C contains enough fluid F1 to completely remove the dissolvable layer **250** while also ensuring that the dissolvable layer **250** can render the fluid F1 opaque. That is, the compartment C may be sized to allow the figurine **200** to be completely submerged into the fluid F1 and/or may be sized based on the amount of material (e.g., paint) included in the dissolvable layer **250**. For example, in the depicted embodiment, the compartment C is taller than the figurine **200** and includes a diameter that is wider than the figurine to allow the figurine **200** to be completely submerged in the compartment C. However, the compartment C is only slightly bigger than the figurine to achieve an adequate ratio of fluid F1 to the amount of material included in the dissolvable layer **250**. In some embodiments, the ratio of fluid to dissolvable material may be in the range of approximately 0.7 Liters of fluid per gram of dissolvable material (e.g., paint) to approximately 1 Liter of fluid per gram of dissolvable material. For example, if the dissolvable layer **250** is formed with approximately 2 grams of dissolvable paint, the compartment C may be sized to receive approximately 1.7 liters of fluid F1.

(38) When the fluid is an opaque fluid F1'', this provides an indication that a transformation is complete and, thus, the figurine **200** can be removed from the compartment C to reveal the underlying body **210** and the overall appearance of the figurine **200**, as is shown in FIG. **10**. That is, as mentioned, once the dissolvable layer **250** is removed (as shown in FIG. **10**), facial features **222**, such as hair **224**, eyes **225**, and lips **226** may be visible to the user (e.g., a child). Additionally or alternatively, the skin complexion **212** of the figurine **200** and/or clothing **236** included on the torso **230** of the underlying body **210** may be visible to the user (e.g., a child).

(39) Now turning to FIGS. **11A** and **11B**, as mentioned, the toy set **10** may include accessories **260**. In the depicted embodiment, each of the accessories **260** is packaged within individual packaging **261** that may be stored within the compartment C (e.g., on, below, above, and/or around the figurine **200**). Packaging the accessories **260** may help to hide the identity of the figurine **200** and may provide yet additional elements of surprise within the toy set **10**. In the depicted embodiment, the accessories **260** include a water retaining element **262** (e.g., a cloth or sponge), a wig **264**, a skirt **268**, and shoes **266**; however, in other embodiments, the play set may include any other accessories (e.g., of any type, style, shape, color, etc.) instead of or in addition to wig **264**, skirt **268**, and shoes **266**. In at least some embodiments, the wig **264**, skirt **268**, and shoes **266** included in a particular toy set **10** may complement or coordinate with the overall appearance of the figurine **200** (e.g., facial features **222**, clothing **236**, and/or complexion **212** of the underlying body **210**) that is initially hidden by dissolvable layer **250**.

(40) Now turning to FIGS. **12**, **13A**, and **13B**, the water retaining element **262** may allow a user to activate thermochromic features included on the underlying body **210**. As is explained in U.S. Pat. No. 5,503,583, which as mentioned above is incorporated herein by reference, thermochromic features may be activated or deactivated with cold or hot energy (e.g., hot or cold water). Thus, in the depicted embodiment, the water retaining element **262** may be dipped in cold fluid F2 (as

shown in FIG. 12) and rubbed on the hair **224** (as shown in FIG. 13A), the eyes **225** (shown in FIG. 13B), and/or the lips **226** (not shown) of the head **220** of the figurine **200**. As shown in FIGS. 13A and 13B, when the eyes **225** have been rubbed with cold water, the eyes **225** may change color, to the color shown at **225'** (e.g., from gray to blue). Similarly, when the lips **226** have been rubbed with cold water, the lips **226** may change color, to the color shown at **226'** (e.g., from tan to red). Finally, when the hair **224** have been rubbed with cold water, the hair **224** may reveal streaks (e.g., from all pink to pink with blue streaks).

(41) FIG. 14 illustrates an example set of characters that may be coated with a dissolvable layer **250** with accessories mounted thereon. The figurine **200** is shown in the center of FIG. 14 with its accessories **260** mounted thereon. By comparison, figurine **300** includes a second set of facial features **322**, a second skin complexion **312**, a second item of clothing **336**, and a second set of accessories **360** that complement its clothing **336** and the overall appearance of the underlying body **310** of figurine **300**. Next, figurine **400** includes a third set of facial features **422**, a third skin complexion **412**, a third item of clothing **436**, and a third set of accessories **460** that complement its clothing **436** and the overall appearance of the underlying body **410** of figurine **400**. Still further, figurine **500** includes a fourth set of facial features **522**, a fourth skin complexion **512**, a fourth item of clothing **536**, and a fourth set of accessories **560** that complement its clothing **536** and the overall appearance of the underlying body **510** of figurine **500**. Finally, figurine **600** includes a fifth set of facial features **622**, a fifth skin complexion **612**, a fifth item of clothing **636**, and a fifth set of accessories **660** that complement its clothing **636** and the overall appearance of the underlying body **610** of figurine **600**.

(42) Notably, the overall dimensions of figurines **200**, **300**, **400**, **500**, and **600** are similar, if not identical. Thus, since the dissolvable layer **250** hides the facial features, skin complexion, and clothing of a figurine, a user will not be able to determine which of figurine **200**, **300**, **400**, **500**, and **600** he or she has purchased until the dissolvable layer **250** is removed from the underlying body which it is coating. Consequently, as discussed above, the dissolvable layer **250** will provide at least one element of surprise for a user.

(43) Now turning to FIGS. 15-20, these figures illustrate an example embodiment of packaging that may include a dissolvable layer formed thereon. As mentioned above, in at least some embodiments, packaging may include a dissolvable layer to hide or conceal a toy figurine disposed therein and/or to create an interesting and surprising reveal of the toy figurine disposed therein. In the depicted embodiment, toy set **70** includes packaging **700** with the dissolvable layer **250** formed on an internal wall **726** of a vessel **720**.

(44) More specifically, in the depicted embodiment, the packaging **700** includes a vessel **720** that is similar to vessel **120** and that supports opaque packaging **710** that is similar to outer packaging **110**. Thus, for brevity, like parts of these components are only discussed briefly below and it is to be understood that any description of parts or features of toy set **10** included above is applicable to like parts or features of toy set **70**. For example, opaque packaging **710** extends from a top **714** to a bottom **716** and may cover any portion of vessel **720**, like outer packaging **110** may cover any portion of entire vessel **120**. As another example, although dissolvable layer **250** is now included on or in packaging **700**, it is to be understood that dissolvable layer **250** may be the same composition, material, etc. as, and may be applied in the same manner as, the dissolvable layer **250** applied to figurine **200**. For example, interior wall **726** may be dipped in or sprayed with a dissolvable paint to create a dissolvable layer **250** thereon.

(45) That said, in the depicted embodiment, vessel **720** includes a sidewall **722** that extends between a bottom **724** and an open top **728** (see FIG. 19) to form an annular container. The interior wall **726** extends across this annular container, between two portions of sidewall **722** to divide the container into a first compartment C1 and a second compartment C2, as shown clearly in FIG. 20. That is, a first side **7261** (or surface **7621**) of interior wall **726** cooperates with sidewall **722** (as well as the bottom **724** and open top **728**) to define a first compartment C1 and a second side **7262**

(or surface **7262**) of interior wall **726**, which is opposite first side **7261**, cooperates with sidewall **722** (as well as the bottom **724** and open top **728**) to define a second compartment C2. In the depicted embodiment, the first compartment C1 receives a figurine **75** (see FIG. **20**) and, thus, may also be referred to as the figurine compartment C1. Meanwhile, the second compartment C2 is configured to receive a fluid to initiate a dissolving action of the dissolvable layer **250** and, thus may also be referred to as the action or fluid compartment C2.

(46) In this particular embodiment, the interior wall **726** extends straight across a central portion of vessel **720** to define two hemispherical compartments C1 and C2 that are about equal in size. However, in other embodiments, interior wall **726** may be any shape and size, and may extend across vessel **720** in any manner (e.g., along a curved path). Still further, in some embodiments, the interior wall **726** need not extend across vessel **720** and, for example, could be concentric with sidewall **722**. Put another way, the sidewall **722** might be hollow and the vessel **720** might not include an interior wall **720**.

(47) As can be seen in FIG. **15**, in the depicted embodiment, the sidewall **722** is substantially transparent, but the opaque packaging **710** and the dissolvable layer **250** on the interior wall **726** substantially conceal the figurine compartment C1. Thus, a user (e.g., a child) cannot see a figurine **75** disposed in the figurine compartment C1 when the packaging **700** is in its non-actuated state S1. In the depicted embodiment, the opaque packaging **710** extends approximately halfway around sidewall **722** to enclose the figurine compartment C1; however, in other embodiments, the figurine compartment C1 could be any size and may be enclosed or hidden in any manner. For example, the sidewall **722** could be partially opaque, include a dissolvable layer **250** formed thereon, or some combination thereof. As a specific example, in some embodiments, the sidewall **722** might be hollow (e.g., define an internal chamber) so that the first compartment C1 is defined interiorly of the sidewall **722**, the second compartment C2 is defined within the sidewall **722**, and a dissolvable layer **250** might coat at least a portion of the hollow sidewall **722** (e.g., an interior side).

(48) Since the sidewall **722** is transparent, the sidewall **722** allows a view of the action compartment C2 which may be entertaining for a user who is opening packaging **700**. In particular, the transparent sidewall **722** provides a view of the first side **7261** of interior wall **726**, which is coated with the dissolvable layer **250**. By comparison, the second side **7262** of interior wall **726** may be transparent and uncoated. Thus, when the dissolvable layer **250** is dissolved, a user may be able to see a figurine **75** stored in figurine compartment C1 through the interior wall **726**, as is shown to varying degrees in FIGS. **17-19**.

(49) As can be seen in FIGS. **15**, **16A**, and **16B**, in the depicted embodiment, the vessel **720** is topped or capped by a lid **730**. In this particular embodiment, the lid **730** is a two-part lid and includes a base **731** and a removable top **732**. The removable top **732** defines a receptacle **736** and includes a rim **734** that can removably engage the base **731**. The receptacle **736** can store accessories **740** when the packaging **700** is in the non-actuated state S1 (e.g., a packaging state) and can hold a fluid F1 when a user wants to fill the action compartment C2 with a fluid. That is, the receptacle **736** allows the removable top **732** to act as pitcher, bucket, or other such container. The base **731** is secured to the vessel **720** via a lid removal mechanism **750** and includes fluid pathways **7312** that extend through the base **731**, from a top of base **731** to the action compartment C2 (see FIG. **16B**). However, in other embodiments, the lid **730** may be a one-piece lid, have more than two pieces, may not act as a container for fluid, and/or may include any other desirable features, provided that the lid **730** can: (a) be releasably attached to the vessel **720**; and (b) funnel or guide fluid into action compartment C2.

(50) Moreover, in the depicted embodiment, the removable top **732** may be detached from the base **731** at any time (e.g., before or after a transformation of packaging **700**), but the base **731** may be detached from the vessel **720** only after a fluid has been introduced into the action compartment C2. This is because a lid removal mechanism **750** secures the base **731** to a top **728** of the vessel **720** until a fluid is introduced into the action compartment C2 via fluid pathways **7312** included in

the base **731** of the lid **730**, as is described in further detail below.

(51) FIGS. **17-19** illustrate the packaging **700** during a transformation. In this particular embodiment, a fluid F1 (e.g., a warm fluid) is poured into the base **731** of lid **730** to initiate a transformation. However, in other embodiments, it is conceivable that the transformation may be caused with fluid F1 in any other manner. For example, the entire packaging **700** might be dunked or immersed in fluid F1 if the dissolvable layer **250** is included on an outer surface of sidewall **722**. Regardless, during a transformation, fluid F1 dissolves or at least begins to dissolve the dissolvable layer **250** so that the figurine **75** can be at least partially seen from an exterior of the packaging **700**. In some embodiments, the figurine **75** and the packaging **700** may both include a dissolvable layer **250** and, thus, exposing the packaging **700** to fluid F1 may provide a view of the figurine **75** without revealing the identity of the toy figurine **75**. However, in the depicted embodiment, figurine **75** is uncoated and, thus, dissolving the dissolvable layer **250** may provide a view of the figurine **75**, at least for a moment.

(52) More specifically, to initiate a transformation, fluid F1 is poured into the base **731** of the lid **730**. The fluid pathways **7312** in the base **731** guide the fluid F1 towards the action compartment C2 and, more specifically, towards the first side **7261** of the interior wall **726**. As the fluid F1 flows over the first side **7261** of the interior wall **726**, the dissolvable layer **250** begins to dissolve as shown in FIGS. **17-19**, revealing more and more of the figurine **75** in an interesting and surprising manner.

(53) In at least some embodiments, the fluid pathways **7312** may be or include funnels or funnel-type elements to guide the water into the interior wall **726**. Additionally or alternatively, although not shown, the fluid pathways **7312** may be angled, swirled, or otherwise non-linear. Non-linear fluid pathways **7312** may allow a fluid to move through the base **731** and into contact with a dissolvable layer **250** included on the interior wall **726**, but will also prevent a user from seeing into the vessel **720**. That said, in other embodiments, the fluid pathways **7312** need not be non-linear since the fluid pathways **7312** lead into the action compartment C2 and the figurine **75** is enclosed within figurine compartment C1, which may be surrounded or enclosed by opaque elements when the packaging **700** is in the non-actuated state S1 (so that the figurine **75** is, for the most part, not visible from outside of the figurine compartment C1).

(54) Additionally, in the depicted embodiment, absorbent pellets **760** are included in the action compartment C2 when the packaging is in its non-actuated state S1 (e.g., resting at the bottom of the action compartment C2). Thus, as the fluid F1 flows towards the bottom of the action compartment C2, the fluid F1 may be absorbed by the absorbent pellets **760**. Since the absorbent pellets **760** expand upon absorbing fluid, the absorbent pellets **760** may begin to rise from the bottom of the action compartment C2, creating another surprising and entertaining element during a transformation of packaging **700**. That is, the absorbent pellets **760** may appear to grow within the action compartment C2.

(55) The absorbent pellets **760** may also be opaque and, thus, as the absorbent pellets **760** rise or grow, the absorbent pellets **760** may obscure the view of the figurine **75** that the dissolving dissolvable layer **250** is beginning to provide (due to fluid F1 dissolving the dissolvable layer **250**). That is, in the depicted embodiment, the view of the figurine **75** is only provided for a moment because the absorbent pellets **760** cover the transparent interior wall **726** as the dissolvable layer **250** dissolves. This may create further entertainment for the user and/or extend the surprise of the figurine reveal. Moreover, as can be seen in FIG. **20**, once the base **731** of lid **730** has been removed from the vessel **720**, the absorbent pellets **760** can be poured out of the vessel **720** and used for explorative play with the figurine **75**.

(56) Now referring to FIGS. **19** and **20**, in the depicted embodiment, the base **731** of lid **730** is secured to the vessel **720** with a lid removal mechanism **750** when the packaging **700** is in the non-actuated state S1. As fluid F1 is introduced into the action compartment C2, the fluid F1 may unlock or loosen the lid removal mechanism **750** to allow the base **731** to be removed from the

vessel **720**. However, other embodiments need not include a lid removal mechanism **750** and the lid **730** or portions thereof may be removably attached to the vessel **720** in any manner. Additionally, in other embodiments, the lid **730** need not guide a fluid F1 therethrough and the packaging or dissolvable layer **250** may hide the figurine **75** in the figurine compartment C1 during introduction of fluid into the action compartment C2 in any manner. For example, underneath the lid **730**, the figurine compartment C1 might be covered with discardable packaging while the action compartment C2 is uncovered.

(57) That said, in the depicted embodiment, the base **731** is substantially solid and opaque, aside from the fluid pathways **7312**. Thus, when base **731** is attached to vessel **720**, compartments C1 and C2 may be substantially closed (or enclosed). However, the base **731** is the only element covering compartments C1 and C2 and, thus, when base **731** is detached or removed from vessel **720**, compartments C1 and C2 are open-top compartments. That is, when base **731** is removed from the vessel **720**, compartments C1 and C2 may be visible from above the vessel **720**. Thus, once base **731** is removed from vessel **720**, the figurine **75** may be removable from the figurine compartment C1. Additionally, if the packaging **700** includes absorbent pellets **760**, the absorbent pellets **760** may be removable from the action compartment C2 when the lid **730** is removed from vessel **720**. In the depicted embodiment, the figurine **75** includes a handle **76** to assist with removal of the figurine from the figurine compartment C1.

(58) Now turning to FIGS. **21-23**, in the depicted embodiment, the lid removal mechanism **750** is a paper-based element that weakens or disintegrates when exposed to fluid F1. For example, the lid removal mechanism **750** may be a water-dissolvable cardboard/chip board member. More specifically, the lid removal mechanism **750** may be a T-shaped, paper or paper-based element with a tongue portion **752** and a lock portion **756**. The tongue portion **752** includes an aperture **754** that aligns with an aperture (not shown) included on the base **731** of the lid **730** when the lid removal mechanism **750** is installed on the lid **730** (e.g., when the packaging **700** is in its non-actuated state S1). Thus, when the packaging **700** is in its non-actuated state S1, a fastener **758** can extend through both the aperture **754** and the aperture included on the base **731** to lock the base **731** to the vessel **720**. In some embodiments, the vessel **720** may also include an aperture that aligns with the apertures of the base **731** and the lid removal mechanism **750** and the fastener **758** may extend through all three apertures.

(59) When the fastener **758** is installed through the apertures in the base **731** and the lid removal mechanism **750** (and the base **731** is installed on the vessel **720**), the lock portion **756** of the lid removal mechanism **750** can prevent upwards movement of the lid removal mechanism **750**, which, in turn, prevents upwards movement of the base **731** of the lid **730** (since fastener **758** is secured through both apertures). Additionally or alternatively, if the fastener **758** extends through apertures in the vessel **720**, the lid **730**, and the lid removal mechanism **750**, the fastener **758** may prevent upwards movement of the lid **730**. In any case, the lid removal mechanism **750** is positioned inwards of the base **731** and the vessel **720**, within the action chamber C2. Thus, when fluid F1 is poured into the action chamber C2, the fluid F1 comes into contact (e.g., runs over) the lid removal mechanism **750**.

(60) When the lid removal mechanism **750** is exposed to fluid F1, the paper or paper-based lid removal mechanism **750** loses structural integrity (e.g., it softens and/or weakens). At this point, upwards movement of the base **731** can cause the fastener **758** to rip or otherwise move through the tongue portion **752**, disconnecting the base **731** from the lid removal mechanism **750** and the vessel **720**. Alternatively, the softened/weakened lid removal mechanism **750** can be pulled away from the vessel **720** (e.g., with the lid **730**) to release the lid **730** from the vessel **720**. Regardless, the lid removal mechanism **750** locks the lid **730**, or at least a portion thereof, to the vessel **720** until a fluid F1 loosens or unlocks the lid removal mechanism **750**. Thus, the lid removal mechanism **750** may be referred to as a fluid- or water-activated unlatching mechanism.

(61) While the toy figurine and packaging presented herein has been illustrated and described in

detail and with reference to specific embodiments thereof, it is nevertheless not intended to be limited to the details shown, since it will be apparent that various modifications and structural changes may be made therein without departing from the scope of the inventions and within the scope and range of equivalents of the claims. In addition, various features from one of the embodiments may be incorporated into another of the embodiments. That is, it is believed that the disclosure set forth above encompasses multiple distinct inventions with independent utility. While each of these inventions has been disclosed in a preferred form, the specific embodiments thereof as disclosed and illustrated herein are not to be considered in a limiting sense as numerous variations are possible. The subject matter of the inventions includes all novel and non-obvious combinations and subcombinations of the various elements, features, functions and/or properties disclosed herein. Accordingly, it is appropriate that the appended claims be construed broadly and in a manner consistent with the scope of the disclosure as set forth in the following claims.

(62) It is also to be understood that the toy figurine and packaging described herein, or portions thereof may be fabricated from any suitable material or combination of materials, such as plastic, foamed plastic, wood, cardboard, pressed paper, metal, supple natural or synthetic materials including, but not limited to, cotton, elastomers, polyester, plastic, rubber, derivatives thereof, and combinations thereof. Suitable plastics may include high-density polyethylene (HDPE), low-density polyethylene (LDPE), polystyrene, acrylonitrile butadiene styrene (ABS), polycarbonate, polyethylene terephthalate (PET), polypropylene, ethylene-vinyl acetate (EVA), or the like. Suitable foamed plastics may include expanded or extruded polystyrene, expanded or extruded polypropylene, EVA foam, derivatives thereof, and combinations thereof.

(63) Additionally, it is to be understood that terms such as “left,” “right,” “top,” “bottom,” “front,” “rear,” “side,” “height,” “length,” “width,” “upper,” “lower,” “interior,” “exterior,” “inner,” “outer” and the like as may be used herein, merely describe points of reference and do not limit the present invention to any particular orientation or configuration. Further, the term “exemplary” is used herein to describe an example or illustration. Any embodiment described herein as exemplary is not to be construed as a preferred or advantageous embodiment, but rather as one example or illustration of a possible embodiment of the invention.

(64) Finally, when used herein, the term “comprises” and its derivations (such as “comprising”, etc.) should not be understood in an excluding sense, that is, these terms should not be interpreted as excluding the possibility that what is described and defined may include further elements, steps, etc. Similarly, where any description recites “a” or “a first” element or the equivalent thereof, such disclosure should be understood to include incorporation of one or more such elements, neither requiring nor excluding two or more such elements. Meanwhile, when used herein, the term “approximately” and terms of its family (such as “approximate”, etc.) should be understood as indicating values very near to those which accompany the aforementioned term. That is to say, a deviation within reasonable limits from an exact value should be accepted, because a skilled person in the art will understand that such a deviation from the values indicated is inevitable due to measurement inaccuracies, etc. The same applies to the terms “about” and “around” and “substantially”.

## Claims

1. A toy play set, comprising: a toy figurine; a vessel within which the toy figurine is packaged, the vessel defining a sealable compartment that, when sealed, defines a fixed volume; and a dissolvable layer disposed on the toy figurine to obscure clothing of the toy figurine underlying the dissolvable layer, wherein the fixed volume of the sealable compartment is sized to receive an amount of fluid sufficient to fully dissolve the dissolvable layer and, once dissolved, the dissolvable layer renders the amount of fluid opaque, and wherein the vessel is at least partially transparent so that, when the dissolvable layer is dissolved and opaque fluid is removed, the clothing of the toy figurine is

visible.

2. The toy play set of claim 1, wherein the sealable compartment is at least partially formed from or covered by opaque materials so that the sealable compartment is substantially opaque prior to removal of the opaque materials.
3. The toy play set of claim 2, wherein the sealable compartment is configured to receive the amount of fluid subsequent to removal, from the vessel, of at least a portion of the opaque materials.
4. The toy play set of claim 1, wherein the fixed volume is sized based on an amount of the dissolvable layer included on the toy figurine to achieve a ratio of the amount of fluid to the amount of the dissolvable layer in a range of 0.7 liter per gram to 1 liter per gram.
5. The toy play set of claim 1, further comprising: opaque outer packaging that, when disposed on the vessel, substantially covers the vessel to hide the toy figurine positioned therein from view; accessories that are coordinated, by color, design, or both color and design, with the clothing of the toy figurine, the accessories being packaged in obscure packaging so that the obscure packaging and the dissolvable layer collectively hide an identity of the toy figurine; or both the opaque outer packaging and the accessories.
6. The toy play set of claim 1, further comprising a hook configured to support the vessel on a display rod at a point of sale.
7. The toy play set of claim 1, wherein obscuring the clothing obscures an identity of the toy figurine, the identity being selected from a set of identities associated with toy figurines of like dimensions.
8. The toy play set of claim 1, wherein obscuring the clothing obscures an overall appearance of the toy figurine, the overall appearance being selected from a set of appearances associated with toy figurines of like dimensions.
9. A toy play set, comprising: a toy figurine; a vessel within which the toy figurine is packaged; a dissolvable layer disposed on the toy figurine to obscure clothing of the toy figurine underlying the dissolvable layer, wherein the dissolvable layer is dissolvable in a fluid and the vessel is at least partially transparent so that, when the dissolvable layer is dissolved, the clothing of the toy figurine is visible; and (a) opaque outer packaging that, when disposed on at least a portion of the vessel, hides at least a portion of the toy figurine positioned therein from view, (b) accessories that are coordinated, by color, design, or both color and design, with the clothing of the toy figurine and are packaged in obscure packaging so that the obscure packaging and the dissolvable layer collectively hide an identity of the toy figurine, or (c) both the opaque outer packaging of (a) and the accessories of (b).
10. The toy play set of claim 9, wherein the identity is selected from a set of identities associated with toy figurines of like dimensions.
11. The toy play set of claim 9, wherein the vessel defines a sealable compartment that, when sealed, defines a fixed volume sized to receive an amount of the fluid sufficient to fully dissolve the dissolvable layer.
12. The toy play set of claim 11, wherein the fixed volume is sized so that, once dissolved, the dissolvable layer renders the amount of fluid opaque.
13. The toy play set of claim 11, wherein the sealable compartment is configured to receive the amount of fluid subsequent to removal, from the vessel, of at least a portion of the opaque outer packaging.
14. The toy play set of claim 11, wherein the fixed volume is sized based on an amount of the dissolvable layer included on the toy figurine to achieve a ratio of the amount of fluid to the amount of the dissolvable layer in a range of 0.7 liter per gram to 1 liter per gram.
15. The toy play set of claim 11, wherein the sealable compartment is at least partially formed from or covered by opaque materials so that the sealable compartment is substantially opaque prior to removal of the opaque materials.

16. The toy play set of claim 9, wherein obscuring the clothing obscures an overall appearance of the toy figurine, the overall appearance being selected from a set of appearances associated with toy figurines of like dimensions.
17. A toy play set, comprising: a toy figurine; a vessel within which the toy figurine is packaged; a dissolvable layer disposed on the toy figurine to obscure at least a portion of an overall appearance of the toy figurine, wherein the dissolvable layer is dissolvable in a fluid and the vessel is at least partially transparent so that, when the dissolvable layer is dissolved, the at least a portion of the overall appearance of the toy figurine is visible; and (a) opaque outer packaging that, when disposed on at least a portion of the vessel, hides at least a portion of the toy figurine positioned therein from view, (b) accessories that are coordinated, by color, design, or both color and design, with the overall appearance of the toy figurine and are packaged in obscure packaging so that the obscure packaging and the dissolvable layer collectively hide an identity of the toy figurine, or (c) both the opaque outer packaging of (a) and the accessories of (b).
18. The toy play set of claim 17, wherein the identity is selected from a set of identities associated with toy figurines of like dimensions.
19. The toy play set of claim 17, wherein the vessel defines a sealable compartment that, when sealed, defines a fixed volume sized to receive an amount of the fluid sufficient to fully dissolve the dissolvable layer.
20. The toy play set of claim 19, wherein the fixed volume is sized based on an amount of the dissolvable layer included on the toy figurine to achieve a ratio of the amount of fluid to the amount of the dissolvable layer in a range of 0.7 liter per gram to 1 liter per gram.
21. A toy play set, comprising: a toy figurine; a vessel within which the toy figurine is packaged, the vessel defining a sealable compartment that, when sealed, defines a fixed volume; and a dissolvable layer disposed on the toy figurine to obscure at least a portion of an overall appearance of the toy figurine, wherein the fixed volume of the sealable compartment is sized to receive an amount of fluid sufficient to fully dissolve the dissolvable layer and, once dissolved, the dissolvable layer renders the amount of fluid opaque, and wherein the vessel is at least partially transparent so that, when the dissolvable layer is dissolved and opaque fluid is removed, the at least a portion of the overall appearance of the toy figurine is visible.
22. The toy play set of claim 21, wherein obscuring the at least a portion of the overall appearance obscures an identity of the toy figurine, the identity being selected from a set of identities associated with toy figurines of like dimensions.
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